

LIVE

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NEWSPAPER

14th December, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

50th WEEK



**IS OUT OF IRAQ... WHAT
NEXT?**

UPSC CSE – GS III

**GS III ... LINKAGES OF ORGANISED CRIME
WITH TERRORISM**



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

14th DECEMBER, 2017

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IS was?

The Islamic State may have lost territory, but it still exists

Iraq Prime Minister Haider al-Abadi has declared victory over the Islamic State, signalling an end to more than four years of conflict that saw Iraq's once-first bleeding without their weapons and then, after foreign assistance, negotiating to restore lost territory. At the peak of its influence, the IS controlled almost a third of Iraq, including Mosul, its second biggest city. Mr. Abadi, who took over as Prime Minister in September 2014 when the country was in the middle of the civil war, adopted a cautious, gradualist approach with direct help from the United States and Iran to take on the IS. Iraqis quickly stopped the IS's southward expansion in the suburbs of Baghdad and then started offensive operations in the group's usual pockets of influence, after capturing cities such as Ramadhi and Fallujah. Iraqi troops moved to Mosul, the jewel in the IS crown, but retained this initiative and Kurdish Peshmerga troops joined the ground battle, as the US provided air cover. When Mosul was liberated in July after nine months of fighting, it was arguable whether a final victory over the IS was just a matter of time. Mr. Abadi claims Iraqi soldiers have established control over the vast Iraq Syria border after making IS fighters flee or retreat from towns where they had retreated after losing a town or city.

For Mr. Abadi and the Iraqi military, this is a moment of both relief and sober reflection. But it may be far too simplistic to conclude that Iraq is totally rid of the IS threat. Perhaps greater challenge they face is healing the wounds of the civil war. Iraq is a divided country today. The resource-rich north, which is mostly Shi'ite, supports the government and is relatively peaceful. In the war-torn north and west, there is no denying that people feel alienated from the Shia-dominated government in Baghdad. The Kurdish Autonomous Region has already held a referendum, against the wishes of Baghdad, in which a majority of voters supported independence. If the government fails to tackle these divisions and let parts of the country drift into anarchy again, groups like the IS will find it an easy breeding ground and recruiting field. The IS may have lost its Iraq, but it would be blind to deny that the group doesn't exist anywhere. It is not known, for instance, what happened to its self-declared Caliph, Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi. In Syria, it still controls territory, even if it is under growing pressure of Russian-American bombing and Kurdish attacks. In 2009-10, al-Qaeda in Iraq had faced similar military setbacks. But as a long-termist organisation, it turned for the worse and civil war broke out in Syria. It regrouped and continued to fight. For Mr. Abadi, it has to be seen that this doesn't repeat itself. In order to do so, he must, besides keeping the military on alert, reach out to the country's disaffected Sunnis and Kurds. Only a united Iraq can hold off the resurrection of the extremists.

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Date : 14th December, 2017

2 IS was?

The Islamic State may have lost territory, but it still exists

Iraqi Prime Minister Haider al-Abadi has declared victory over the Islamic State, signalling an end to more than three years of battle that saw Iraqi troops first fleeing without their weapons and then, with foreign assistance, regrouping to recover lost territory. At the peak of its influence, the IS controlled almost a third of Iraq, including Mosul, its second largest city. Mr. Abadi, who took over as Prime Minister in September 2014 when the country was in the middle of the civil war, adopted a cautious, gradualist approach with direct help from the United States and Iran to take on the IS. Iraqi troops first stopped the IS's southward expansion in the suburbs of Baghdad and then started offensive operations in the group's small pockets of influence. After capturing cities such as Ramadi and Fallujah, Iraqi troops moved to Mosul, the jewel in the IS crown. Iran-trained Shia militias and Kurdish Peshmerga troops joined the ground battle, as the U.S. provided air cover. When Mosul was liberated in July after nine months of fighting, it was arguable whether a final victory over the IS was just a matter of time. Mr. Abadi claims Iraqi soldiers have established control over the vast Iraq-Syria border after ousting IS fighters from small border towns where they had retreated after losing urban areas.

...Contd.

2 IS was?

For Mr. Abadi and the Iraqi military, this is a moment of both relief and accomplishment. But it may be far too simplistic to conclude that Iraq is totally rid of the IS threat. Perhaps a greater challenge they face is healing the wounds of the civil war. Iraq is a divided country today. The resource-rich south, which is mostly Shia, supports the government and is relatively peaceful. In the war-stricken north and west, there is no doubting that people feel alienated from the Shia-dominated government in Baghdad. The Kurdish Autonomous Region has already held a referendum, against the wishes of Baghdad, in which a majority of voters supported independence. If the government fails to tackle these divisions and lets parts of the country drift into anarchy again, groups like the IS will find it an easy breeding ground and regain a footing. The IS may have lost territory, but it would be blind to deny that the group doesn't exist anymore. It is not known, for instance, what happened to its self-declared Caliph, Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi. In Syria it still controls territory, even if it is under growing pressure of Russian-American bombing and Kurdish attacks. In 2006-07, al-Qaeda in Iraq had faced similar military setbacks. But when Iraq's sectarian rivalry took a turn for the worse and civil war broke out in Syria, it regrouped and reinvented itself as the IS. Mr. Abadi has to see that this doesn't repeat itself. In order to do so, he must, besides keeping the military on alert, reach out to the country's disaffected Sunnis and Kurds. Only a united Iraq can hold off the resurrection of the extremists.





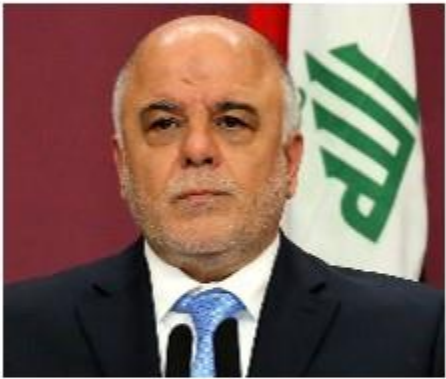
IRAQ AND ISLAMIC STATE



- 1 After 3 years of civil war, Iraq declared victory over Islamic State.
- 2 It took direct help from United States and Iran. Iraqi troops first stopped IS expansion in the suburbs of Baghdad.
- 3 It captured cities Ramadi and Fallujah and Mosul.
- 4 Iran-trained Shia militias and Kurdish Peshmerga forces joined the ground battle and the US provided air cover.

Iraqi Prime Minister said that the soldiers have established control over the vast Iraq-Syria border after ousting IS fighters.

ISLAMIC STATE OUT OF IRAQ ... ONLY EXISTS IN SOME POCKETS OF SYRIA



Haider al-Abadi
Prime Minister, Iraq

+



It provides
air cover

+



Shia Militias

+



Peshmerga
Forces



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Now, Islamic State is out of Iraq



A DECADE AGO...

- 1 In 2006-07, al-Qaeda in Iraq had faced similar military setbacks.
- 2 Because of civil war in Syria and sectarian rivalry in Iraq, it regrouped and reinvented itself as IS by 2014.

The Prime Minister has to see that this does not repeat itself.



BUT WHAT ABOUT INTERNAL DIVISIONS?

- 1 The resource rich South is mostly Shia and supports the Government and is relatively peaceful.
- 2 In North and West, people feel alienated from the Shia-dominated Government.
- 3 Kurdish Autonomous Region has already held a referendum, against the wishes of Baghdad.



KURDISTAN

- Official borders of the Region of Iraqi Kurdistan
- Territory controlled by Iraqi Kurdistan
- Territory claimed by Iraqi Kurdistan

SYRIA

IRAQ

IRAN

Cyprus

Lebanon

Sea

Israel

JORDAN

KUWAIT

Aqaba



Besides keeping the military on alert, it should reach out to country's disaffected Sunnis and Kurds.

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SINCERE THANKS
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